

Sophie Fortz, Postdoctoral Researcher

✉ sophie.fortz@gmail.com

☎ +32 491/55.86.23

🐦 @FortzSophie

🌐 <https://sfortz.github.io/>

🌐 <https://orcid.org/0000-0001-9687-8587>



The long term goal of my research is to enhance software reliability through the automation of verification and validation tasks. Leveraging my expertise in behavioural inference, I aim to design model-based approaches tailored for complex systems such as variability-intensive, quantum, and AI-based software.

During my Ph.D. at the University of Namur, I inferred behavioural models for variability-intensive systems, *i.e.*, Featured Transition Systems. This research builds bridges between software product lines, automata learning, and deep learning research communities. This Ph.D. was partly funded by the FNRS EoS (Excellence of Science) VeriLearn project, before I obtained a FRIA (FNRS) Grant. In November 2023, I joined King's College London as a postdoctoral researcher on the VSL-Q project. Our mission within this project is to provide verified simulations for large-scale quantum systems, tackling practical challenges such as platform specificities, noise, and scalability. This collaborative effort brings together experts from diverse fields including physics, programming languages, and software engineering.

Research Interests

- Software Variability 📌 Software product line engineering, configurable processes, variability-intensive system behaviour, featured transition systems, variability mining.
- Automata Learning 📌 Active automata learning, behavioural model learning, software reverse engineering.
- Quantum Computing 📌 Quantum computing, verified software, high-level modelling.
- Artificial Intelligence 📌 Deep Learning, symbolic AI, AI for SE, SE for AI.

Experience

- Feb. 2026 – Feb. 2028 📌 **Postdoctoral Researcher.** DiverSE group, Inria, University of Rennes, CNRS, IRISA, France.
- Nov. 2023 – Sep. 2025 📌 **Postdoctoral Researcher.** Software Systems group, Department of Informatics, Faculty of Natural, Mathematical & Engineering Sciences, King's College London, United Kingdom.
- Oct. 2023 – Nov. 2023 📌 **Postdoctoral Researcher.** PRECISE, NaDi, Faculty of Computer Science, University of Namur, Belgium.
- Oct. 2020 – Sept. 2023 📌 **PhD Student under FRIA Grant (FRS-FNRS).** PRECISE, NaDi, Faculty of Computer Science, University of Namur, Belgium.
- Sept. 2019 – Sept. 2020 📌 **PhD Student.** PRECISE, NaDi, Faculty of Computer Science, University of Namur, Belgium.

Education

- 2025 – 2030 ■ **National Qualification for Associate Professor (Maître de Conférences).**
Section 27: Computer Science. The national qualification is a requirement to obtain a permanent faculty position in France (*Maître de Conférences*), recognizing research excellence, teaching experience, and academic service.
- 2019 – 2023 ■ **Ph.D. in Software Engineering.**
Thesis title: *Learning Featured Transition Systems*. Supervisors: Dr. Gilles Perrouin & Prof. Patrick Heymans. University of Namur, Namur, Belgium.
- 2017 – 2019 ■ **M.Sc. Computer Science. (Magna Cum Laude).**
Software Engineering specialty. Thesis title: *SAT-Based Concolic Testing in Prolog*. Supervisors: Prof. Wim Vanhoof. University of Namur, Namur, Belgium.
- 2014 – 2017 ■ **B.Sc. Computer Science. (Cum Laude).**
Mathematics and English options, University of Namur, Namur, Belgium.

Teaching & Supervision

- 2025–2026 ■ **Master Thesis Supervision:** co-supervising a Master’s student from the University of Namur on their final-year research project.
- 2019–2023 ■ **Software Testing:** project supervision, MSc Level, ± 15 students, University of Namur.
- 2019–2022 ■ **Mathematics Fundamentals for Computer Science:** exercise sessions on recurrent equations and cryptography basics, BSc Level, $2 \times \pm 40$ students, University of Namur.
- 2020–2021 ■ **Introduction to the Scientific Approach:** one group project supervision, BSc Level, 2 students, University of Namur.

Projects

I have actively contributed to several research projects, both as a PhD student and as a postdoctoral researcher.

- CONFVERT ■ **Green Software Configurations.** This postdoctoral project investigates how software configuration choices influence energy consumption and performance across complex, variability-intensive systems. CONFVERT aims to identify “green” configurations (i.e., settings that minimise energy use while maintaining acceptable performance) by modelling deep cross-layer variability and learning from large-scale empirical data. The project focuses on developing robust predictive and optimisation techniques, running reproducible studies on widely used open-source stacks, and producing actionable guidelines, datasets, and open tools for the community. 2026–2028. Supported by DiverSE team (IRISA/Inria & University of Rennes) and Brittany region. Keywords: Software Variability, Green Software, Performance–Energy Trade-offs, Configuration Optimisation, Empirical Software Engineering.

Projects (continued)

- QAssure ■ **Assurance of Quantum Technology Systems.** Innovate UK-funded project under the “Scalable Quantum Network Technologies: Collaborative R&D” programme. I am part of this consortium, led by BT Group, to develop methodologies for assuring quantum systems such as Quantum Key Distribution (QKD). 2024–2025. Partners: BT Group (coordinator), National Physical Laboratory (NPL), University of Bristol, Cystel, HSBC, KETS Quantum Security, King’s College London, Loughborough University, NodeQ, Toshiba Europe Ltd, and Quentangle. Keywords: Quantum Key Distribution, Quantum Assurance, Cybersecurity.
- VSL-Q ■ **Verified Simulation for Large Quantum Systems.** This project brings together researchers from software engineering, programming languages, and quantum physics to address the increasing complexity of quantum computing systems and the stringent reliability demands of future applications. The goal is to create a verified end-to-end framework that connects high-level programming languages to low-level implementations on various physical quantum platforms. VSL-Q proposes a layered architecture with verified mappings between layers, ensuring reliable compilation from high-level programs to low-level, reliability-aware implementations. A key case study involves simulating fermionic systems to evaluate the approach’s scalability. 2023–2025. Partners: King’s College London (coordinator), University of Oxford. Keywords: Quantum Computing, Verified Software, High-level Modelling.
- ModeMCQ-RoaRQ ■ **Robust and Reliable Quantum Computing.** Funded by the Engineering and Physical Sciences Research Council, this project brings together a cross-disciplinary community of researchers in quantum computing and computer science to tackle the challenge of delivering robust, reliable, and trustworthy quantum computing. The programme aims to establish a framework for quantum computation verification across key layers of quantum computing stacks. One key investigation, *ModeMCQ*, focuses on model-based monitoring and calibration of quantum computations, targeting the development of platform-independent programming paradigms for NISQ algorithms with automatic error mitigation strategies. 2023–2026. ModeMCQ Partners: King’s College London (KCL), University of Oxford. Keywords: Quantum Computing, NISQ, Error Mitigation, Quantum Verification.
- LiFTS ■ **Learning Featured Transition Systems.** This PhD project, funded by a competitive individual FRIA Grant from the FRS-FNRS, aimed to advance the learning of Featured Transition Systems (FTS), a formalism used for modelling the behaviour of variability-intensive systems. The research focused on combining automata learning techniques with deep learning to efficiently explore and understand complex, variable-rich systems. 2019–2023. Keywords: Featured Transition Systems, Automata Learning, Deep Learning.

Projects (continued)

- VeriLearn  **Verifying Systems that Learn.** The goal of this project is to integrate the disciplines of software verification and machine learning to provide strong guarantees for adaptive software systems. VeriLearn addresses key questions around how to verify systems that modify themselves through learning, ensuring they meet ethical, privacy, and societal concerns. The project focuses on developing techniques to combine logic, probability, and machine learning, with an emphasis on interpretable models like probabilistic logic programming. This research aims to establish a framework for mathematically verifiable AI systems. Excellence of Science (EoS) project, 2018–2023. Partners: KU Leuven (coordinator), UNamur, ULB. Keywords: Machine Learning, Software Verification, AI Safety.

Distinctions & Awards

- 2024  Distinguished Reviewer Award, 28th International Systems and Software Product Line Conference.
- 2019–2020  Most Pedagogical Teaching Assistant, Students' award, University of Namur.
- 2018–2019  Most Dedicated Master's student, Students' award, University of Namur.
- 2016–2017  Most Dedicated Bachelor's student, Students' award, University of Namur.

Invited Talks & Seminars

- UCL 2025  Invited talk on “*Mutation Analysis for NISQ Programs*” for the Software Systems Engineering Group Seminar. The audience included MSc Software Systems Engineering students and members of the research group. Given on March 26, 2025, at University College London, London.
- WGiS 2025  Invited talk for the 5th Women and Girls in Science (WGiS) Day, titled “*Mutation Analysis for Noisy Quantum Programs*”. Given on February 13, 2025, at the University of Namur, Namur.
- UCLouvain 2024  Invited talk for the INGI Lunchtime Seminar, titled “*Mutation Analysis for NISQ Programs*”. Given on October 3, 2024, at Université Catholique de Louvain, Louvain-la-Neuve.
- UNamur 2024  Invited talk in the “*Actuality in Data Science*” course for Master's students, titled “*Where Software Engineering Meets Quantum Logic: A Research Perspective*”. Given on October 2, 2024, at the University of Namur, Namur.

Invited Talks & Seminars (continued)

- Dagstuhl 2023 ■ Invited participant in Dagstuhl Seminar 23492 on “*Model Learning for Improved Trustworthiness in Autonomous Systems*”, held from December 3–8, 2023, at Schloss Dagstuhl – Leibniz Center for Informatics, Germany. The seminar gathered experts in software engineering, model learning, machine learning, and autonomous systems to explore how learning-based modelling can enhance the safety, reliability, and transparency of AI-enabled, robotic, and autonomous systems. Discussions addressed key challenges such as variability-intensive systems, system evolution and adaptation, heterogeneous model learning, and compositional learning. I contributed to a *Research Agenda for Active Automata Learning*, which surveyed active automata learning methods across application scenarios, environments, and desired guarantees. We identified major challenges toward these goals, conducted a brief bibliographic study of the state of the art, and outlined initial directions for addressing these challenges.

Community Service

- Guest Editor ■ **Automated Software Engineering**, Special issue on Quantum Software Engineering (with Anila Mjeda and Marcos Lordello Chaim), 2026.
- Organisation committees ■ **VARIABILITY**: International Conference on Software and Systems Reuse, Product Lines, and Configuration, 2026 (Proceeding chair).
- **Q-SE**: International Workshop on Quantum Software Engineering (Web & Publicity chair), co-located with ICSE, 2025 and 2026.
- **SPLC**: ACM Software Product Line Conference, 2024 (Publicity chair) and 2025 (Doctoral Symposium co-chair).
- **QSANER**: International Workshop on Quantum Software Analysis, Evolution and Reengineering (co-chair), co-located with SANER, 2025.
- **ICTSS**: International Conference on Testing Software and Systems (Challenge Track co-chair), 2024.
- **LearnAut**: Learning and Automata (Co-chair), co-located with ICALP / LiCS / FSCD, 2024.
- Program Committees ■ **VARIABILITY**: International Conference on Software and Systems Reuse, Product Lines, and Configuration, 2026 (Doctoral Symposium and Project Showcase).
- **womENCourage**: ACM Celebration of Women in Computing (Poster track), 2026.

Community Service (continued)

- **GPCE:** ACM SIGPLAN International Conference on Generative Programming: Concepts and Experiences (Research track), co-located with ECOOP, 2026.
- **CAiSE:** International Conference on Advanced Information Systems Engineering (Research track), 2026.
- **ASE:** IEEE/ACM International Conference on Automated Software Engineering (Student Research Competition), 2025.
- **SSBSE:** Symposium on Search-Based Software Engineering (Challenge Track), 2024 & 2025.
- **SPLC:** ACM System and Software Product Line Conference, 2022 (Research track, as a sub-reviewer), 2023 (Demonstration & Tools), 2024 & 2025 (Research track).
- **Re:Volution:** International Workshop on Reverse Variability Engineering and Evolution of Software-Intensive Systems, co-located with SPLC, 2025.
- **ISSTA:** ACM SIGSOFT International Symposium on Software Testing and Analysis (Artefact evaluation), 2025.
- **GI @ ICSE:** International Workshop on Genetic Improvement, co-located with ICSE, 2025.
- **ICST:** IEEE International Conference on Software Testing, Verification and Validation (Poster track), 2025.
- **VaMoS:** International Working Conference on Variability Modelling of Software-Intensive Systems, 2025.
- **BENEVOL:** Belgium-Netherlands Software Evolution Workshop, 2024.
- **ICTAC:** International Colloquium on Theoretical Aspects of Computing (Research track), 2024.
- **ECOOP:** European Conference on Object-Oriented Programming (Artefacts, Extended Review Committee), 2024.
- **ESEC-FSE:** ACM Joint European Software Engineering Conference and Symposium on the Foundations of Software Engineering (Artefacts), 2023.

Community Service (continued)

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| | <ul style="list-style-type: none">■ ICSR: International Conference on Software and Systems Reuse (Research track, as a sub-reviewer), 2022. |
| Journal Reviewing | <ul style="list-style-type: none">■ TOSEM: ACM Transactions on Software Engineering and Methodology. Publisher: ACM.■ STVR: Software Testing, Verification and Reliability. Publisher: Wiley.■ SCICO: Science of Computer Programming. Publisher: Elsevier.■ TSE: Transactions on Software Engineering. Publisher: IEEE.■ JSS: Journal of Systems and Software. Publisher: Elsevier.■ SoSyM: International Journal on Software and Systems Modeling. Publisher: Springer.■ SQJ: Software Quality Journal. Publisher: Springer.■ EMSE: Empirical Software Engineering (as a sub-reviewer). Publisher: Springer. |
| Other Community Services | <ul style="list-style-type: none">■ Strategic Reflection Group on Software Variability Conferences: I am an active member of a reflection group that brings together the steering committees of the three major conferences in the field of software variability: SPLC (ACM Systems and Software Product Line Conference), ICSR (International Conference on Systems and Software Reuse), and VaMoS (International Working Conference on Variability Modelling of Software-Intensive Systems). This group is dedicated to shaping the future of these events and fostering stronger synergies within the community, including discussions around a potential merger or the creation of a new, unified conference. As an engaged member of both the SPLC and VaMoS communities, I was honoured to be invited to join the group after initiating and leading several community-wide discussions—both on social media and during a dedicated panel at SPLC. I am especially proud to represent the younger generation of researchers and to be one of the few female voices involved in these strategic conversations.■ Master Thesis Juries: Member of several juries for master thesis.■ UNamur Computer Science Faculty Council: Student representative, then scientific representative (for one year each).■ Students Fairs: Representing and promoting the UNamur Computer Science Faculty at several Students Fairs; |

Miscellaneous Experience

- 2025  **Royal Society Summer Science Exhibition**, London, UK. I took part in the 2025 Royal Society Summer Science Exhibition as a member of the King's College London team invited to develop and present two interactive demos for the Quantum Zone. Alongside nine colleagues, I co-designed and showcased the demos throughout the week-long event, which welcomed over 7,500 participants from the general public, schools, and industry. Our first demo, *Quantum Music*, aimed to introduce newcomers to fundamental quantum computing concepts—such as "what is a quantum program?"—through analogies with music theory. The second demo offered a more technical perspective by exploring *Quantum Key Distribution (QKD)*, focusing on the core principles of the BB84 algorithm. This experience strengthened my science communication skills and my ability to make complex topics accessible and engaging to diverse audiences.
- 2019–2023  **ALMIN board member and president**, University of Namur, Belgium. ALMIN is the alumni association of the Computer Science Faculty at the University of Namur, dedicated to fostering connections between graduates and supporting the student community. As a board member, I contributed to organising events and networking opportunities for alumni and students. I was a board member of the association since my graduation in 2019, and took its presidency from 2021 to 2023.
- 2001–2023  **Girl Guide member, youth leader, and national trainer**, Guides Catholiques de Belgique, Belgium. My involvement with the Girl Guides began as a young participant, and over the years, it grew into a series of leadership roles where I supported and mentored youth through outdoor adventures, team-building activities, and community projects. Starting in 2013, I took on the role of youth leader, working first with children aged 8–12 (2013–2015) and later with adolescents aged 12–16 (2015–2016). From 2017 to 2020, I led groups of young adults with mental disabilities, organizing inclusive activities that fostered confidence and social skills. Alongside these roles, I obtained a *Holiday Centre Trainer's Certificate* in 2014 and became a national trainer in 2015, responsible for preparing and mentoring new leaders. After more than two decades of dedicated service, I concluded my Girl Guide journey in 2023.
- 2019  **Research internship**, Department of Computer Systems and Computation, Polytechnic University of Valencia, Spain. During my master thesis, I have done three months of research at the polytechnic university of Valencia (Spain), under the supervision of Prof. German Vidal. My work on concolic testing for logic programming was nominated for the Jean Fichet award (best master thesis award).
- 2017 – 2019  **CSLabs secretary and board member**, Computer Science Labs (CSLabs), Namur, Belgium. CSLabs is a non-profit organisation founded by students from Unamur's Faculty of Computer Science, in order to promote computer science externally and provide trainings in different fields by and for students.

Languages

French  Native (mother tongue).

English  B2-level (score of 72 on the Pearson PTE Academic test, 2023).

Languages (continued)

Dutch  Basic knowledge.

French Belgian Sign Language  Basic knowledge.

Publications

- 1 Bensoussan, A., Chachkarova, E., Even-Mendoza, K., **Fortz, S.**, Klimis, V., & Mousavi, M. (2026). Toward live noise fingerprinting for discrepancy analysis in quantum software engineering. *19th IEEE International Conference on Software Testing, Verification and Validation (ICST) 2026*.
- 2 **Fortz, S.**, Ghassemi, F., Henry, L., Howar, F., Neele, T., Rot, J., & Suilen, M. (2026). A research agenda for active automata learning [Special issue: Dagstuhl 23492 (Trust-Dagstuhl)]. *International Journal on Software Tools for Technology Transfer*, 1–22.
- 3 Bensoussan, A., Chachkarova, E., Even-Mendoza, K., **Fortz, S.**, & Lenihan, C. (2025). Accelerq: Accelerating quantum eigensolvers with machine learning on quantum simulators. *Proc. ACM Program. Lang.*, 9(OOPSLA2), 2279–2309.
- 4 Klimis, V., Bensoussan, A., Chachkarova, E., Even-Mendoza, K., **Fortz, S.**, & Lenihan, C. (2025). Shaking up quantum simulators with fuzzing and rigour. *Proc. ACM Program. Lang.*, 9(OOPSLA2), 1400–1428.
- 5 d'Aloisio, G., **Fortz, S.**, Hanna, C., Fortunato, D., Bensoussan, A., Usandizaga, E. M., & Sarro, F. (2024). Exploring llm-driven explanations for quantum algorithms (emerging results, vision and reflection papers track). *Proceedings of the 18th ACM/IEEE International Symposium on Empirical Software Engineering and Measurement (ESEM)*, 475–481.
- 6 **Fortz, S.**, Temple, P., Devroey, X., Heymans, P., & Perrouin, G. (2024). Varyminions: Leveraging rnn to identify variants in variability-intensive systems' logs. *Empirical Software Engineering*, 29(4), 99.
- 7 **Fortz, S.**, Temple, P., Devroey, X., & Perrouin, G. (2024). Towards feature-based ml-enabled behaviour location (new and controversial idea track). *Proceedings of the 18th International Working Conference on Variability Modelling of Software-Intensive Systems (VaMoS)*, 152–154.
- 8 **Fortz, S.** (2023). Variability-aware behavioural learning (doctoral symposium). *Proceedings of the 27th ACM International Systems and Software Product Line Conference (SPLC) - Volume B*, 11–15.
- 9 dos Santos, E. L., **Fortz, S.**, Schobbens, P., & Perrouin, G. (2022). Identifying architectural smells in self-adaptive systems at runtime. *13ème édition de la Conférence francophone sur les Architectures Logicielles (CAL)*.
- 10 dos Santos, E. L., **Fortz, S.**, Perrouin, G., & Schobbens, P. (2021). A vision to identify architectural smells in self-adaptive systems using behavioral maps. *4th Context-aware, Autonomous and Smart Architectures International Workshop (CASA@ECSA)*, 2978.
- 11 dos Santos, E. L., **Fortz, S.**, Schobbens, P., & Perrouin, G. (2021). Behavioral maps: Identifying architectural smells in self-adaptive systems at runtime. *Software Architecture*, 13365, 159–180.
- 12 **Fortz, S.** (2021). LIFTS: learning featured transition systems (doctoral symposium). *Proceedings of the 25th ACM International Systems and Software Product Line Conference (SPLC) - Volume B*, 1–6.
- 13 **Fortz, S.**, Temple, P., Devroey, X., Heymans, P., & Perrouin, G. (2021). VaryMinions: Leveraging RNNs to identify variants in event logs. *Proceedings of the 5th International Workshop on Machine Learning Techniques for Software Quality Evolution (MaLTesQuE@ESEC/FSE)*, 13–18.

- 14 Fortz, S., Mesnard, F., Payet, É., Perrouin, G., Vanhoof, W., & Vidal, G. (2020). An SMT-based concolic testing tool for logic programs. *15th International Symposium on Functional and Logic Programming (FLOPS)*, 12073, 215–219.

Bibliometrics

Total Number of Publications:	14
Total Number of Citations:	65
H-index (Google Scholar):	5

See <https://scholar.google.co.uk/citations?user=cfV6X6kAAAAJ> for the full list of publications.

Master Thesis

- Title 🔖 SAT-Based Concolic Testing in Prolog
- Supervisor 🔖 Prof. Dr. Wim Vanhoof
- Year 🔖 2019
- Abstract 🔖 Concolic testing has been studied for years in the field of imperative programming. However, we can only find a very few cases where this technique is applied to other paradigms, like logic programming. This master thesis aims at presenting a full method to apply both concrete and symbolic execution in parallel on Prolog programs. Our approach is based on a new definition of path coverage, specific to logic programming and called "choice coverage". This criteria was defined for the first time by Mesnard et al. (2015). We also introduce a prototype implementation of our algorithm.
- Keywords 🔖 Concolic execution, symbolic execution, software testing, choice coverage, Prolog, logic programming.

Ph.D. Thesis

- Title 🔖 Learning Featured Transition Systems
- Supervisors 🔖 Dr. Gilles Perrouin and Prof. Dr. Patrick Heymans
- Year 🔖 2023

Ph.D. Thesis (continued)

Abstract ■ *Variability-intensive Systems (VISs)* are software-based systems whose characteristics and behaviour can be modified by the activation or deactivation of some options. Addressing variability proactively during software engineering (SE) activities means shifting from reasoning on individual systems to *reasoning on families of systems*. Adopting appropriate variability management techniques can yield important *economies of scale* and quality improvements. Conversely, variability can also be a curse, especially for Quality Assurance (QA), *i.e., verification and testing* of such systems, due to the combinatorial explosion of the number of software variants. Indeed, by combining only 33 Boolean options, we can define more variants of a system than the number of people on Earth. Verifying or testing each variant individually is thus impossible in most practical cases.

About a decade ago, *Featured Transition Systems (FTSs)* were introduced as a formalism to represent, and reason on, *the behaviour of VISs*. Instead of representing each variant by a (classical) transition system, an FTS bears annotations that relate transitions to options through *feature expressions*. FTSs thus make it possible to reason at the family level by modelling all the variants of a system in a single behavioural model. FTSs have been shown to significantly improve the possibilities and execution time of automated QA activities such as model-checking and model-based testing. They have also shown their usefulness to guide design exploration activities. Yet, as most model-based approaches, FTS modelling requires both *strong human expertise and significant effort* that would be unaffordable in many cases, in particular for large legacy systems with outdated specifications and/or systems that evolve continuously.

Therefore, this thesis aims *to automatically learn FTSs from existing artefacts*, to ease the burden of modelling FTS and support continuous QA activities. To answer this research challenge, we propose a two-phase approach. First, we rely on deep learning techniques to locate variability from execution traces. For this purpose, we implemented a tool called *VaryMinions*. Then, we use these annotated traces to learn an FTS. In this second part, we adapt the seminal L^* algorithm to *learn behavioural variability*. Both frameworks are open-source and we evaluated them separately on several datasets of different sizes and origins (*e.g.*, software product lines and configurable business processes).

Keywords ■ Variability-intensive Systems, Software Product Line, Featured Transition Systems, Reverse Engineering, Active Automata Learning, Variability Mining

Sophie Fortz

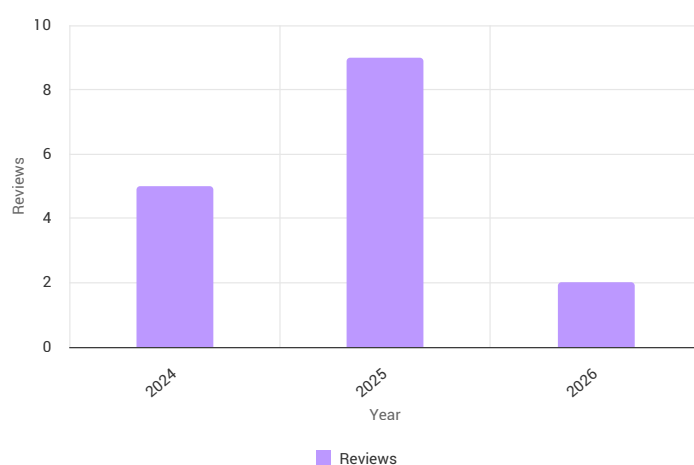
<https://www.webofscience.com/wos/author/rid/JMB-6052-2023>

Web of Science ResearcherID: [JMB-6052-2023](#)

ORCID: 0000-0001-9687-8587

Verified Reviews

Review Summary



Reviewer Summary

For manuscripts reviewed from date range April 2021 - April 2026

(4) Software and Systems Modeling

(3) Science of Computer Programmi...

(1) Software Testing, Verification & ...

(1) IEEE Transactions on Software E...

(4) Journal of Systems and Software

(2) Empirical Software Engineering

(1) ACM Transactions on Software E...